record Myanmarese ‘repair missions’ to Mahabodhi, ranging from the medieval to the modern, are those in which Ashoka figures prominently. A thirteenth century CE epigraph from Bodh Gaya, written in the Burmese language and script, while recording a mission for repair dispatched by a king Dhammaraja from Burma, simultaneously remembers the building of the original temple there by Ashoka. ‘When 218 years of the Buddha’s dispensation had elapsed, one of the 84,000 *caityas* built by Siri Dhammasoka (i.e. the Maurya emperor Asoka), king of Jambudvipa, at the place where the milk rice offering had been made (a clear reference to Sujata’s offering of *payasa* to Siddhartha at Bodhgaya) fell into ruin due to the stress of age and time.’[27] A similar association was made more than five hundred years later when, in 1875, Mindon, king of Burma, sought permission to renovate the Mahabodhi complex: he too invoked Ashoka. Two millennia had passed since the Mauryan emperor was active there, with many phases of renovation since, and yet the Burmese king said he wanted to undertake the ‘repair of the sacred chaitya built by the King Dharmasoka over the site of the Aparajita throne.’[28]

A different kind of remembrance which also stretched across a wider expanse appeared in the accounts of another group of Asian pilgrims, the Buddhist Chinese monks who travelled to India. This began in around the fifth century CE, before the Burmese endowments at Bodh Gaya, when Faxian came from Changan city in Shensi across a northern route that traversed Central Asia. He travelled extensively in India and then moved to Sri Lanka. His purpose in India was to obtain the correct rules and regulations of the *Vinaya Pitaka* texts. His travels were simultaneously a variant on anthropological fieldwork, a kind of ethnographic documentation of what he noticed, ranging from the topography of the lands through which he passed to the sorts of clothes that people wore, the festivals and tales around places and people, the nature of shrines (Buddhist and Brahmanic) and monasteries, and a great deal else. His account highlights the fact that,